

REG-01: CMS Interoperability and Prior Authorization Final Rule (CMS-0057-F)

Training summary prepared for the Bellcourt case study. Simplified for learning purposes; not legal advice and not a substitute for the source text.

Who it applies to

Medicare Advantage organizations, state Medicaid and CHIP programs (fee-for-service and managed care), and qualified health plans on the federally facilitated exchanges. It does not apply directly to self-funded employer plans. Delegated vendors such as TPAs are bound through their contracts.

Decision timeframes (from January 2026)

- Standard requests: decision within 7 calendar days (previously up to 14).
- Expedited requests: decision within 72 hours.
- Timeframe requirements apply to MA, Medicaid and CHIP; they do not apply to exchange (ACA) plans.

Denial reasons

Payers must give a specific reason for any denial, whatever the channel used to communicate the decision (portal, fax, email, mail or phone).

Public reporting

Payers must post annual aggregated metrics: approval rates, denial rates, approvals after appeal, and average and median decision times. The first reports, covering 2025, were due March 31, 2026.

APIs (from January 2027)

- Expanded Patient Access API including prior authorization information.
- Provider Access API.
- Payer-to-Payer API.
- Prior Authorization API that can receive requests and return decisions electronically.